



MOCKING THE MARKET: Gallery of Rogues by Nayanaa Kanodia

everywhere, in museums, in schools, and on the streets. The curiosity for the arts was great. For the first time I saw serpentine queues outside museums while the only place one saw lines in India was outside temples and cinema houses. One instance struck me as an artist. I saw a lady at the Musee de Orsay holding her three-year-old in front of a Cezanne painting. The child's exclamation was met with the mother explaining the form. This is the revolution perhaps that we artists would like to see. Where encouragement is like this, and art is enjoyed. An understanding of the arts is something that is barely beginning here, with more and more people going to galleries, which become spaces where artists can create their art.

But now perhaps, in some way, the reformation has come. There is certainly a boom in the art world. From our paintings going at the highest prices, we have also managed to bring Indian art to a level where people know it's something more than the ancient and traditional arts. The economic boom in the Indian art world has two consequences—the artist now has the confidence to paint as and when he wants. This was a major problem earlier. I myself at one time thought of becoming a teacher to support myself, as did others. Even Prabhakar Barve worked at the Weaver's Service Centre and Bhupen Khakhar juggled between being a chartered accountant and an artist. Now it has become a full-time profession, and our visibility is partly due to the increasing number of art connoisseurs, who not only buy works of art but also follow an artist's oeuvre in its various phases. Such aspects make an artist feel wanted in society. This can have a flip side too. The artists might become slaves to the market. But this affects only a few; if it was so, many of us would not be on the invitation lists of important galleries.

The essence for many of us remains to disturb and create questions. The very tag now of an Indian artist instills a responsibility in many of us. The future seems bright, with more and more forms of arts coming to the forefront like architecture, and sculpture. There are more opportunities for the younger lot, and one feels reassured that perhaps one day Indian masters will have a place of their own in the international art arena. With all of us pushing boundaries to create realities of our own, it seems the canvas of Indian art is all set to become more colourful.

as told to Bushra Ahmed

The writer is an acclaimed painter

ABHISHEK PODDAR, art collector, 2006

"Earlier one looked for the soul of the artist in the work. Today bidders merely see signatures."